

RENAISSANCE

How much did medicine really change during the Medical Renaissance?

Name: _____

Class: _____

Progress & Assessment Tracker	Effort	Level	Teacher Comments	
L1: KT2.1: Did the Renaissance change beliefs about the causes of illness?				
L2: KT2.2: Did treatments improve during the Renaissance?				
L3: KT2.3: How significant were William Harvey and the Great Plague?				
Final Unit Grade:				

L1: KT2.1: Did the Renaissance change beliefs about the causes of illness?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain how Thomas Sydenham's scientific approach to observation changed the diagnosis of disease.
- ☐ Assess the role of the printing press and the Royal Society in communicating and spreading scientific ideas.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 6

1. In what year did the Black Death arrive in England?

2. What did medieval people believe caused the Black Death?

3. State one method used to try to prevent the Black Death.

4. Why did the Black Death cause such a high death toll?

5. To what extent did the Black Death change medical ideas?

6. Recall: Who was Claudius Galen and what was their key contribution to medicine?

Vocabulary Check

Fill in the blanks using the vocabulary words below.

Humanism Nullius in Verba Animalcules
--

During the Medical Renaissance, a cultural shift known as _____ encouraged doctors and scientists to think for themselves, question ancient texts, and verify claims through empirical observation. This hands-on mindset was championed by the Royal Society, whose strict motto _____ drove researchers to reject traditional theories in favor of rigorous experimentation. Although new scientific instruments like advanced microscopes allowed pioneers to observe microscopic _____ for the very first time, these discoveries had little immediate impact on treating patients because there was no proof that these tiny organisms actually caused illness.

Q1. Identify one invention that helped spread new ideas during the Renaissance.

Q2. Describe what Vesalius discovered about Galen.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q3)

How did Sydenham's belief that diseases were like plants or animals challenge the traditional Theory of the Four Humours?

- ☐ A. It proved that diseases were caused by invisible germs.
- ☐ B. It meant diseases were separate entities with specific symptoms, rather than a personal imbalance of a patient's humours.
- ☐ C. It showed that diseases could only be cured by herbal remedies.
- ☐ D. It proved that diseases were a punishment from God.

Q4. Explain the purpose of the Royal Society.

Q5. Evaluate the extent to which the Renaissance changed beliefs about the causes of illness.

Pair & Share Activity

Prompt: In the period c1500-c1700, was the work of individual physicians like Thomas Sydenham more important in challenging traditional medical beliefs than institutional developments like the founding of the Royal Society?

Think: Jot down your choice and one piece of evidence from the sources (e.g., Sydenham's Observationes Medicae classifying diseases like scarlet fever vs. the Royal Society publishing Leeuwenhoek's discoveries in Philosophical Transactions).

Your Notes:

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TEACHER FEEDBACK / D.I.R.T.

Exam Q12. Explain why there were changes in the way ideas about the causes of disease and illness were communicated in the period c1500-c1700. (12 marks)

You may use the following in your answer:

- The printing press
- The Royal Society

You must also use information of your own.

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General Notes

This image shows a full page of blank, lined paper. It features approximately 20 horizontal blue lines spaced evenly across the page, typical of notebook or legal stationery. The lines are thin and light blue, set against a plain white background. There are no margins, text, or other markings present.

☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

L2: KT2.2: Did treatments improve during the Renaissance?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Analyze the continuities and changes in Renaissance treatments and preventions, including the impact of exploration and alchemy.
- ☐ Explain how institutional changes, specifically the Dissolution of the Monasteries, altered hospital care in England.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 5

1. What was the Renaissance?

2. What invention helped spread new medical ideas during the Renaissance?

3. Who was Thomas Sydenham?

4. Why did the influence of the Church begin to decline in the Renaissance?

5. Explain why the Theory of the Four Humours was still used despite new discoveries.

Vocabulary Check

Write a historically accurate sentence connecting two terms from the glossary box below.

Transference | Iatrochemistry | Dissolution of the Monasteries

Your Sentence:

Q1. Identify one new herbal remedy brought from the 'New World'.

Q2. Describe the approach of Thomas Sydenham.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q3)

Why was the importation of cinchona bark from South America a more successful treatment than traditional humoral methods?

- ☐ A. It contained quinine, which actually treated the specific symptoms of malaria, rather than just attempting to rebalance humours.
- ☐ B. It was a holy relic blessed by the Pope.
- ☐ C. It killed the germs that caused malaria.
- ☐ D. It was used to draw bad humours out of the skin.

Q4. Explain why treatments for ordinary people hardly changed during the Renaissance.

Q5. To what extent did the 'New World' improve medical treatments?

Pair & Share Activity

Prompt: In the period c1500-c1700, did the introduction of global herbal remedies and chemical cures represent a more significant improvement in treatment than the gradual reforms made to the training of physicians?

Think: Jot down your choice and one piece of evidence from the sources (such as the successful use of cinchona bark for malaria versus the fact that physicians' training was still largely book-based with very little hands-on dissection experience).

Your Notes:

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TEACHER FEEDBACK / D.I.R.T.

Exam Q16. Explain why there was rapid progress in anatomical knowledge in the Renaissance period (c1500-c1700). (12 marks)

You may use the following in your answer:

- Andreas Vesalius
- The printing press

You must also use information of your own.

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Teacher Comment:

L3: KT2.3: How significant were William Harvey and the Great Plague?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain the significance of William Harvey's discovery and the reasons for its limited short-term impact.
- ☐ Compare the government and public responses to the 1665 Great Plague with the 1348 Black Death.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 6

1. Who wrote 'On the Fabric of the Human Body' (1543)?

2. What did Vesalius prove about Galen's anatomical ideas?

3. What was 'transference'?

4. Explain how hospitals changed during the Renaissance.

5. Why did Vesalius' discoveries have limited immediate impact on everyday medical treatment?

6. Recall: Who was Andreas Vesalius and what was their key contribution to medicine?

Vocabulary Check

Write a clear definition and a historically accurate sentence for the term: **Circulation**

Q1. Identify what William Harvey proved about the blood.

Q2. Describe how Harvey proved Galen wrong.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q3)

What was the main reason why Harvey's discovery of blood circulation did not immediately change medical treatments?

- ☐ A. Because he refused to publish his findings in a book.
- ☐ B. Because the Church banned his book and executed him.
- ☐ C. Because knowing how the blood circulated did not provide doctors with any new drugs or cures for sick patients.
- ☐ D. Because he still believed the liver manufactured blood.

Q4. Explain how the Great Plague of 1665 was dealt with differently from the Black Death.

Q5. Evaluate the short-term significance of Harvey's discovery.

Pair & Share Activity

Prompt: Why was William Harvey's brilliant discovery of blood circulation completely ignored in the prevention and treatment of the Great Plague of 1665?

Think: Jot down your explanation and one piece of evidence (e.g., how knowing that blood flows did not help cure a disease when germs were still undiscovered, or how doctors did not believe Harvey because they felt it had no practical clinical application).

Your Notes:

GCSE Exam Practice

Q6. 'The most effective method of preventing the spread of the Great Plague (1665) was the use of quarantine.' How far do you agree? Explain your answer. (16 marks + 4 marks for SPaG)

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TEACHER FEEDBACK / D.I.R.T.

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TEACHER FEEDBACK / D.I.R.T.

Exam Q19. 'The most effective method of preventing the spread of the Great Plague (1665) was the use of quarantine.' How far do you agree? Explain your answer. (16 marks + 4 marks for SPaG) (16 marks)

You may use the following in your answer:

- Watchmen
- The animal cull

You must also use information of your own.

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General Notes

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☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

Factors Overview: Renaissance

Edexcel focuses heavily on the factors that drove medical progress (or held it back). For each factor below, write one specific historical example from this period that either helped or hindered medical progress.

Factor	Specific Historical Example & Impact
Individuals	
The Church & Religion	
Government & Wealth	
Science & Technology	
Attitudes in Society	
War	

Factor	Specific Historical Example & Impact

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